Biscuits of Glory

By Bruce Coville

BENJIE: **(Pg 20-28)** I am haunted by biscuits -- Elvira Thistledown's biscuits, to be more precise. But I don't have any regrets. If I had it to do over again, I would still eat one, if only to free that poor woman from her curse. I'd do it even knowing how it was going to affect the rest of my life.

ELVIRA: *(singing softly, sweetly and sadly, almost like a hymn)* Biscuits, biscuits of glory, This is my story, Biscuits of glory . . .

INTRODUCTION

When Benjie Perkins meets the ghost of Elvira Thistledown he learns the strange story behind why she haunts his kitchen -- and what he must do to free her from her curse. Biscuits of Glory by Bruce Coville

BENJIE: I was ten when it happened. We had just moved into a new house. Well, new to us; it was really a very old one.

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On our third night in the house, I heard a clatter in the kitchen. Now all old houses have their noises, their own personal creaks and groans. But something about this particular noise didn't sound right to me. So I grabbed my baseball bat and headed for the stairs.

Trying not to wake my parents, I tiptoed along the hall, past the peeling wallpaper, past the bathroom, on to the head of the stairs. I paused and listened.

Something was definitely moving in the kitchen. I could hear scrapes and thumps, soft and gentle. I was about to go wake my parents when I heard something else -- something totally unexpected.

I heard a woman singing. I leaned forward and closed my eyes, straining to hear.

ELVIRA: *(singing softly, sweetly and sadly, almost like a hymn)* Biscuits, biscuits of glory, This is my story, Biscuits of glory . . .

BENJIE: By now the hair was standing up on the back of

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my neck. Yet somehow I didn't think anyone who sounded so sad and sweet could hurt me.

ELVIRA: Biscuits, biscuits of glory.

BENJIE: Pushing lightly on the kitchen door, I swung it open just a crack. When I peeked through, I let out a little squeak of fright. There was no one in sight, not a person to be seen.

What I did see was a bag of flour, which wouldn't have been that unusual, except for the fact that this bag was *floating* through the air. The bag of flour opened, seemingly by itself. A measuring cup drifted into the air, then dipped into the flour bag. As the cup came out of the bag, a little thrill ran down my spine. Suddenly I could see the hand that was holding it -- covered with flour!

ELVIRA: Biscuits, biscuits of glory . . . *(her voice catches as she chokes back a sob)*

BENJIE: I couldn't help myself. Stepping through the door into the kitchen . . . "What is it? What's wrong?"

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The flour-covered hand jerked sideways, knocking over the container of baking powder.

ELVIRA: *(startled and frightened)* Who are you?

BENJIE: I'm Benjie Perkins. I live here. Who are you?

ELVIRA: *(whispering)* Elvira Thistledown. I died here.

BENJIE: What are you doing?

ELVIRA: Making biscuits. *(sets the baking powder upright)* I make biscuits every Saturday night. Saturday at midnight. It's my curse. *(she continues to work)* I always loved to make biscuits. My mother taught me when I was only seven years old.

BENJIE: I hate to interrupt, but is it possible for you to become visible? I might feel less nervous if you did.

ELVIRA: Well, it's not easy. But you seem like a nice boy. Just a minute and I'll see what I can do.

BENJIE: Soon a milky light began to glow in front of me. It started out kind of blobby, but after a minute or two it condensed into the form of a woman. She was younger and prettier than I had expected.

ELVIRA: Better? *(she returns to her work)* It was vanity did

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me in. I was so proud of my biscuits that I just couldn't stand it when that awful Dan McCarty moved into town and started bragging that ***he*** made the best biscuits in the state.

DAN: Why, my biscuits are lighter than dandelion fluff. Apt to float away on the first stiff breeze.

ELVIRA: After a while his proud talk got to me, and I challenged him to a contest -- A biscuit bake-off. Both of us to make biscuits, results to be judged by Reverend Zephyr of the Baptist Church.

BENJIE: Did you win? *(to audience)* She was busy working on her biscuits, so she didn't answer right away. She had turned the dough out onto the counter and was kneading it lightly

ELVIRA: I lost. I lost, and that was the beginning of my downfall. I became obsessed with biscuits. I swore I would make a better biscuit than Dan McCarty or die trying. *(she finishes kneading and begins to cut the dough into rounds)* We began to have a weekly contest, Dan and I. Every Sunday morning we'd take

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our biscuits to church, and after the service Reverend Zephyr would try them out. He'd measure them. He'd weigh them. Finally he'd taste them, first plain, then with butter, then with honey. And every Sunday he'd turn to me and say,

REV. ZEPHYR: I'm sorry, Elvira, but Dan's biscuits are just lighter and fluffier than yours.

ELVIRA: *(Popping the tray into the oven)* I was like a madwoman. *(she gradually become more scary)* I worked day and night, night and day, trying every combination I could think of to make my biscuits lighter, fluffier, more wonderful than any that had ever been made. I wanted biscuits that would float out of the oven and melt in your mouth. I wanted biscuits that would make the angels weep with envy. *(whispering)* The key is in the baking powder. *(her eyes wild)*

BENJIE: I was beginning to be frightened again. I wondered if she really was crazy - and if she was, just what a crazy ghost might do.

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ELVIRA: One Sunday I was sure I had it; I came to church with a basket of biscuits that were like a stack of tiny featherbeds. But after the judging, Reverend Zephyr shook his head sadly and said,

REV. ZEPHYR: Sorry, Elvira.

ELVIRA: By the next Saturday night I was wild, desperate, half insane. In a fit of desperation, I dumped an entire can of baking powder into my dough.

BENJIE: What happened?

ELVIRA: The oven door blew off and killed me on the spot. And ever since, I've been doomed to bake a batch of biscuits every Saturday at midnight, as punishment for my pride. What's worse, I finally know the secret. Learned it on the other side. These biscuits are the lightest, fluffiest ever made, Benjie. But no one has ever tasted them, and I can't rest until someone does.

BENJIE: How come no one has ever tasted them?

ELVIRA: *(near tears)* How can they? My biscuits of glory

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are so light and fluffy they float right out of the oven and disappear through the ceiling. If I could leave them on the counter overnight, someone might have tried them by now. But they're always gone before anyone gets a chance.

BENJIE: These biscuits of yours-they wouldn't hurt someone who ate them, would they?

ELVIRA: Of course not! These are biscuits of glory. One bite and you'll never be the same.

BENJIE: What if I grabbed one as it came out of the oven?

ELVIRA: You'd burn your hand.

BENJIE: Wait here! *(to audience)* I scurried up the stairs and rummaged through my room until I found what I was looking for. I went down the stairs two at a time, hoping to make it to the kitchen before Elvira's biscuits came out of the oven. She was standing by the big old oven as I slipped through the swinging door.

ELVIRA: What's that?

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BENJIE: My catcher's mitt. Are the biscuits ready?

ELVIRA: To perfection! *(she opens the oven door)*

BENJIE: Out floated a dozen of the most perfect biscuits I had ever seen-light, golden brown, high and fluffy, crusty around the edges. *(he reaches out with the mitt and snags a biscuit)*

ELVIRA: Careful, they're hot!

BENJIE: *(Ignoring her warning, he takes the biscuit from the glove)* Ow! *(he loses his grip and the biscuit heads toward the ceiling. He scrambles to snag another one)* I was more careful this time, cupping the glove over it and holding it tenderly while it cooled. I could feel the heat, but the leather protected me. Finally I thought it was safe to try a bite. *(Elvira watches with wide eyes and he takes the biscuit from his glove and lifts it to his lips)*

It was astonishing, the most incredible biscuit I have ever tasted! *(he begins to float off the ground)* Suddenly I realized something even more astonishing: ***I*** was floating! I had lifted right off the counter and

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was hovering in midair. I worried about getting down, but as I chewed and swallowed, I drifted gently to the floor. *(to Elvira)* What an amazing biscuit. I feel like I've died and gone to heaven!

ELVIRA: So do Eyeeeeeee! *(Elvira floats through the roof and disappears)*

BENJIE: . . . . as if she were being snatched into the sky. That was the last I ever saw of Elvira Thistledown. Her biscuits, however, haunt me still. It's not just the memory of their taste, though I have never again tasted anything so fine. It's the effect of the darned things. See, whenever I get too happy, or too excited, or begin thinking about those biscuits too much, I start to float. It gets a little embarrassing sometimes. I'll tell you this, though. Unlike some people, I'm not afraid of what happens after you die. I know what I'll find waiting on the other side . . . *(Sings)* Biscuits. Biscuits of glory.

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